

passengers disembarked, went through customs and immigration, and then boarded a Pakistan Railways train for their ultimate destination.

Prior to this, a through service between Jodhpur in Rajasthan and Karachi did exist, but was discontinued around 1965. It restarted in 2006, but did not provide a direct connection. Passengers travelled from Jodhpur to Munabao, a village near the desert town of Barmer on the Indian border, went through customs and immigration, before being taken to the Zero Point Station in Pakistan. There, they boarded the Thar Express to Karachi. This line sought to revive the train that once ran between Ahmedabad, in Gujarat, and Pakistan's Hyderabad, during British rule.

However, services on both these trains have been quite inconsistent, given the tenuous nature of diplomatic relations between the two countries.

Fostering friendship

The people of Bangladesh and India waited for a train connection between the two countries for 42 years. There were direct buses and flights, but the railways carried a deeper connection, symbolic of a time when the two countries were part of a whole. In fact, before Partition, a regular overnight train ran from Kolkata to Goalanda and Dhaka, both in Bangladesh. Until the 1965 Indo-Pakistan war, three trains ran between India and East Pakistan, including the East Bengal Mail, East Bengal Express, and Barishal Express.

In April 2008, the train called Maitree or Friendship Express began service, travelling 500 km from Kolkata to Dhaka. It was a result of bilateral talks between India and Bangladesh. A second line was inaugurated in 2017 connecting Kolkata with Khulna, a city in Bangladesh, an attempt to revive the Barishal Express route. Called Bandhan (or bond) Express, the train travels 172 km and makes three stops.

New routes

The most recent international connection has been a 34-km-line that will run from Jayanagar in Bihar to Janakpur in the neighbouring